15. Young Bravehearts

The Prime Minister presented the 2013 National Bravery Awards to 25 children on Friday, 24 January 2014, two days before Republic Day. Among these 25 children, 9 are girls and The Bharat Award was conferred upon eight-and-a-half year old Mahika Gupta from Delhi.

On June 16, 2013, Mahika Gupta was in Kedarnath with her family. Suddenly, flash floods struck. The area was filled with muddy flood-water. Mahika could not see her parents or relatives but heard her four-year old brother crying. Mahika did not know how to swim. She was hit with stones carried by water. But bravely, she waded out till she found her brother and dragged him to safety. There, she held on tightly to her brother for hours. When she saw a light, she waved for help. After that they were both rescued. With her determination and presence of mind, she saved her own life and that of her brother.

Bravery is in doing the right thing – even when one is afraid.

We become just by performing just actions.
We become brave by performing brave actions.

Shubham Santosh Chaudhari from Maharashtra has been given Sanjay Chopra Award for his exemplary courage. He was on his way back from school on 11 August 2012. He saw that a van had burst into flames on the national highway. A crowd had gathered but they were watching helplessly. Shubham rushed to the vehicle and tried to open the door but the handle was too hot to hold. Shubham quickly broke the van's window and unlocked the door from inside. There were two girls in the van. He pulled them out of the burning van and saved their lives.

Every year, National Bravery Awards are given to young children for their outstanding deeds of bravery. These children present inspiring examples for other children. You can read about their acts of courage in the newspapers or on the internet.

> The brave man is not he who does not feel afraid, but he who conquers that fear.
>
> – Nelson Mandela

Things to do :

1. What brave thing did Mahika do ? Write about it in one or two lines.
2. What brave thing did Shubham do ? Write about it in one or two lines.
3. Copy, in good handwriting, the quotes given above in coloured boxes.
4. You also do some nice things, however small they may be. For example, helping a younger child, telling the truth even when you have made a mistake.

   Write about any two such things that you have done.